speeches against the judicial reform and other anti-democratic moves of the Netanyahu government.

Recently though, Himi announced that he would not enter the political fray. Why? What happened? Just when he had reached the necessary visibility and enjoyed growing support? Well, it all became clear some three days ago, when a scandal that was brewing for some time exploded: our hero had apparently exposed himself and masturbated in front of a female lawyer who had come to ask for a recommendation for being appointed to the judiciary. She told it to somebody who told it to somebody else, who told it to a journalist. It became the main item of all news programs; Himi stepped down from his position in the Bar Association, and the police are probably going to open an investigation. At least, Himi has now become well known to every Israeli. Alas.

Khan al-Ahmar is symbolic of the general situation in the West Bank. Slowly but surely Israeli settlements grow in number, notwithstanding Palestinian and international opposition. The Israeli left tries to slow down the settlers' progress but cannot stop it, because part of the population that moves to the territories moves there to get cheaper housing in a scenic environment: messianic ideology incites, cheap real estate entices.

Thursday, February 2

Increasingly one finds allusions in the news to a semi-hidden foundation financing the right-wing onslaught on Israeli democracy: Kohelet (Ecclesiastes), supposedly financed—at least in part—by rich American Jews. Whatever the case with Kohelet may be, there is clearly a general anti-liberal offensive on all fronts: judicial, religious, educational, in the media, and, of course, the Occupied Territories. Nonetheless, two steps forward, one step back. Thus, for the time being only, the new plan to dismantle the Israeli Public Broadcasting Corporation has been postponed.